

Passage 1. *An author laments how convenience is laden with pitfalls.*

- 1 Convenience has emerged as a powerful force shaping our lives and economies, as we constantly find more efficient and easier ways of doing tasks. While this has bestowed us productivity, the bullet train of convenience has eroded loftier ideals such as meaning, individuality and freedom.
- 2 The pernicious effects of convenience are most observable when we sacrifice the public good for personal expediency. For instance, a recent move to convert heating in Boston homes from oil to electricity, which is more environmentally friendly, was hampered by the difficulty in finding contractors willing to do the onerous job. The same can be said of our addiction to single-use plastics and gas-guzzling cars, against the harrowing backdrop of plastic pollution and soaring carbon emissions. Convenience oils the wheels of our busy lives, enmeshing us in environmentally destructive habits. Not only that, we risk public health when we avoid tedious precautions, or even decry their infringement on our 'liberty'. Take the debate over masks and other measures to contain the Covid-19 virus. For many, wearing a mask is an inconvenience, but being able to work and live free from the exposure to a deadly disease is true liberty. Yet regrettably, not everyone agrees.
- 3 The technologies of mass individualisation have also facilitated convenient curation. We desire the seamless experience of 'plug and play', avoiding analogue discovery (which now seems excessively effortful) in favour of algorithmic curation – from our taste in music and movies, to online finds and even friends. How many of us have landed on Spotify playlists generated by algorithms, only to be fed more songs of the same? Today's technologies also strip us of all but the most superficial expressions of individuality. For instance, Tiktok, with its recognisable format, restricts us to vertical videos of stilted dances set against preset music. We do not consume, but are consumed by stifling conformity.
- 4 With its promise of effortlessness, convenience also threatens to erase the tedious tasks that actually give life meaning. Perhaps our humanity is expressed in such 'inconvenient' and time-consuming pursuits. This is not to place Luddites* on a pedestal, but to reclaim the richness of human experience – from the knitted sweater and stone-baked pizza, to the hand-written letter and photographs in a dark room. Convenience is also all destination and no journey, as it avoids difficulty, an integral feature of human experience. Climbing a mountain is different from taking the tram to the top, even if you end up at the same place. Convenient choices erode our character because they prevent us from encountering meaningful resistance – as in melding raw ingredients, fixing a broken appliance, or encountering the limits of our own bodies.
- 5 More than just a matter of individual choice, convenience touches on broader questions of how we conduct our lives and societies. The addiction to convenience is built on economic productivity, which demands: Do more, faster, or be left behind. We cannot, or are afraid to, slow down on the treadmill of hyper-efficiency and endless competition. Brought to the extreme, entire societies can metastasise into deep existential collapse. Can anyone blame, for instance, the 'lie-flat' generation in China for opting out of a high-octane life to pursue a simpler, slower existence? Slow food, slow fashion, slow living... all around the world, these have become crucial counter-movements to the evils of convenience.
- 6 Let us disembark from the bullet train of convenience, where our lives are organised in total, efficient conformity. Let us, amidst the harried and unthinking rush-hour crowd, contemplate that difficult tasks take time, and teach us something about the world and our place in it.

**A Luddite refers to a person opposed to new technology or ways of working.*

Passage 2. *An author praises the virtues of convenience.*

- 1 In our fast-paced world, where time is a finite resource, the pursuit of convenience has precipitated technological advancements, enhancing efficiency and overall well-being. Technological innovations such as mobile phones, smart home devices, and online platforms have revolutionised the way we perform daily tasks. Tasks that once required significant effort can now be completed with just a few clicks, freeing up valuable time for more meaningful activities. 5
- 2 The advent of online shopping has provided consumers with the convenience of purchasing products from the comfort of their homes. This not only saves the commute to physical stores, but also allows for a more efficient comparison of products and prices which facilitates better decision-making. Convenience hurtles us through the complexities of our daily tasks with unparalleled speed and productivity. 10
- 3 Convenience is also closely tied to healthy living. Pre-packaged salads and ready-to-eat meals make it easier for individuals to make healthier choices, even when faced with time constraints. Advancements in telemedicine have made healthcare more accessible. Virtual consultations and remote monitoring tools enable individuals to seek medical advice without the need for travel, removing barriers to regular health check-ups and consultations. 15
- 4 Surprisingly, convenience can also be advantageous to the environment. Innovations in eco-friendly packaging and sustainable practices allow for convenience and environmental conservation to be achieved simultaneously, as seen in containers made from recycled plastic and plantable packaging. Harnessing the power of convenience enables us to practise true environmental stewardship. As we continue to discover new ways to streamline our lives, the pursuit of convenience will remain a driving force in shaping the future. 20

Passage 3. *A commentator contemplates how convenience robs us spiritually.*

- 1 We live in a world where depth and richness are sacrificed at the altar of convenience. Spiritual practices crucial for grounding oneself in a deeper understanding of life often involve rituals, reflection, and meaningful conversations. The pursuit of convenience leads individuals to prioritise speed and efficiency – we choose the diet pill over the daily run, ready soundbites over reasoned reflection, and a text message over a tangible meeting. Most observably, we have lost the art of deep communication with others, amidst the cacophony of devices. 5

- 2 It is also in the slow, deliberative, and gritty ways of doing things – such as handling cloth, clay and carpentry with our hands, or cooking from scratch – that we refocus our mental energies and master mindfulness. The artistry our hands once wielded has been supplanted by automated machines. The sense of touch, once intimately tied to the sensory joy of creation, is likewise diminished. Where our grandparents treasured the bespoke clothes tailored lovingly on their sewing machine, we now indulge in fast-fashion hauls every season, only to consign them to the landfills soon after. Regrettably, we have also replaced carefully home-cooked meals with processed food packaged in plastic containers, ready to be consumed and discarded. 10

- 3 We have also bent our sacred selves into the ethic of convenience, such as by choosing our lifestyles, communities of worship and even partners from the endless buffet of online options. Convenience has diminished our character and bred a consumerist mindset where one's needs and desires take precedence over patience and faithfulness; difficult situations or people provoke an immediate response that one 'always has other options' easily found on a mobile application. 15
20

- 4 Convenience has given us many things, but has also taken away much from us. We have placed our planet on a consumerist treadmill, turning our eyes away from the impending ecological disaster. This is the inconvenient truth that demands our conviction to turn things around.